

Trend tracker:

1. **Trend title:** Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) replaces Traditional PR SEO. 📌
2. **Source Details:**

- Source 1 (Article): PR Daily - "2026 PR trends, according to five industry experts"

Link: <https://www.prdaily.com/2026-pr-trends-according-to-five-industry-experts/>

Date of publication: December 2025

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

Generative Engine Optimization (GEO), an essential new PR capability

"In 2026, brand reputation will be increasingly shaped not by what people search for, but by what AI answers," says Melanie Klausner, EVP of Consumer at Havas Red.

As generative AI becomes the default source of information for consumers, journalists and creators alike, the way brands manage their visibility is evolving. Traditional SEO is giving way to Generative Engine Optimization (GEO), which aims to improve brands' visibility in the responses AI generates for user queries. Every article, interview and expert quote feeds the models shaping tomorrow's AI answers.

That means earned media often becomes the data on which these engines are trained. The brands cited most often by authoritative outlets are the ones most likely to appear in AI-generated summaries of the most trusted companies.

"For communicators, this demands a new mindset and fundamental shift: publishing with the intent to be machine-cited. Brands must prioritize authoritative storytelling, proprietary insights and expert voices to ensure they're surfaced in AI summaries."

AI becomes a critical source to monitor

Will Swope, associate director of Issues Management & Monitoring at the National Cattlemen's Beef Association, predicts that in 2026, "communications teams will need to adjust to add more time and resources to AI monitoring."

Just as PR professionals once learned to navigate social platforms like Twitter and TikTok, they now need to track what AI systems are saying about their brands. Swope points to early reports from OpenAI and Anthropic that reveal what people ask large language models, and how the models respond.

By monitoring those conversations through tools such as [Meltwater's GenAI Lens](#), communicators can see how their brand or industry is represented inside major AI platforms, helping them catch inaccuracies or bias before they spread.

Figure 1: PR and GEO

Note: Note: This excerpt explains the concept of Generative Engine Optimization. From PR trends 2026: The hottest public relations trends, by M. Rodesevich, 2026, <https://prlab.co/blog/pr-trends-2026/>. Copyright 2026 by PRLab

- Source 2 (Industry blog): PR Lab - “PR trends 2026: The Hottest Public Relations Trends”

Link: <https://prlab.co/blog/pr-trends-2026/>

Date of publication: 16 March 2026

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

PR and GEO

Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) is a content optimization strategy that helps your content show up in answers from **LLMs and AI search engines like ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, and Claude**. People now ask questions and expect instant, summarized answers instead of scrolling through search results. By 2025, **ChatGPT reached 800 million weekly active users**, doubling in only a few months. This creates a new channel for PR teams to influence through the **same authoritative placements and expert positioning that have always built credibility**.

GEO connects PR directly to business visibility. When someone asks a chatbot a question, they often get answers without even visiting a website. Show up in those responses, and you're positioned as the authority instantly. **Media coverage** now does double the work: **it boosts search rankings while increasing your chances of being cited by AI systems** as GEO prioritizes brand mentions and citations

Figure 2: PR and GEO

Note: This excerpt explains the connection between GEO and brand visibility. From PR trends 2026: The hottest public relations trends, by M. Rodesevich, 2026, <https://prlab.co/blog/pr-trends-2026/>. Copyright 2026 by PRLab.

- Source 3 (Professional Article): The PR Net - "The shifts redefining Marketing and Communications in 2026"

Link: <https://theprnet.com/journals/marketing-and-communications-trends-2026>

Data of publication: n.d

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

EARNED MEDIA MATTERS MOST IN THE AGE OF GEO | CAITLIN COPPLE, FOUNDING PARTNER, FULL SWING PUBLIC RELATIONS

"Fifty-eight percent of consumers now use AI to evaluate products and services, double last year, which means purchase decisions are increasingly shaped by what the internet says about your brand, not what you say about yourself. Generative search prioritizes earned media, with 27–49% of citations coming from journalistic sources, depending on the query. If companies aren't showing up in credible outlets, AI outputs will reflect that absence. In 2026, closing your credibility gap means closing your AI visibility gap."

"Generative search is becoming the default, and that means PR matters more than paid marketing because AI models reward ongoing, authoritative coverage over one-off announcements. Since AI systems often train on data that may lag six to twelve months, the stories brands place today determine how they appear (or not) in tomorrow's generative search results. Earned media already drives the vast majority of AI citations, with over 95% pulled from unpaid media sources. The winners in 2026 will be the brands that show up consistently in credible media, not those who only pitch during a launch."

EDITORIAL AND SOCIAL – A TWO-WAY INFLUENCE LOOP | SHAUNA SOLUM, EXECUTIVE VICE PRESIDENT, LAFORCE

"The relationship between editorial and social isn't just blurred – it's a constant two-way exchange of influence. On one side, outlets are extending editorial content into multi-part social series and immersive digital storytelling that sparks social buzz, amplifying editorial reach far beyond the page. On the other, social media is the cultural pulse point driving editorial – what trends on feeds often dictates what gets covered by traditional media. For brands, the takeaway is clear: success means playing both sides – craft stories that spark shareable moments and feel native to social, while also using social signals to anticipate and shape the editorial narratives that matter most."

Figure 3

Earned Media Matters Most in the Age of GEO

Note: An assessment of the importance of earned media in increasing citations on AI. From "The shifts redefining marketing and communications in 2026," by The PR Net, 2026, <https://theprnet.com/journals/marketing-and-communications-trends-2026>. Copyright 2026 by The PR Net

3. **Trend description:** In 2026, the communications landscape is shifting from traditional Search Engine Optimization (SEO) to Generative Engine Optimization (GEO). As audiences expandingly rely on AI-generated summaries (like Google's AI Overviews)

rather than clicking through traditional search results, “zero-click PR” has become the norm. This trend involves suitably structuring press releases, corporate narratives and digital content so that Large Language Models (LLMs) can easily crawl, understand, and confidently cite the brand as a highly authoritative source. It is significant because the traditional website access metrics are decreasing, which forces communicators finding new ways to maintain brand visibility. This alteration is being efficiently led by tech giants integrating AI into search platforms, alongside forward-thinking PR agencies and thought leaders who are advocating for optimizing content for machine readability while maintaining strict factual accuracy.

4. **Your initial reflection:** As a future media and communication professional, understanding GEO is important. Merely writing compelling copy is no longer sufficient; I must also understand how algorithms interpret that information. Mastering how to make content “AI-readable” and securing citations in AI search overviews will give me a competitive advantage in digital PR and strategic corporate communications.

Trend 2

1. Trend Title: AI Content Fatigue Drives Demand for Human-Centric Storytelling.

2. Source Details:

- Source 1 (Podcast): Michelle Garrett - “2026 PR Trends You Need To Know”

Link: <https://michellegarrett.com/podcasts/2026-pr-trends/>

Date of publication: December 2025

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

Time Code: 16:20 (AI and PR: The Deep Fakes Issue)

- Source 2 (Expert Blog): Sophie Pomme - “The 5 Communications Trends Turning 2026 into a Reckoning)

Link: <https://sophiepomme.com/communications-trends-2026/>

Date of publication: March 2026

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

The Rise (and Fall) of AI-Generated Influencers

AI-generated influencers and bots have invaded social media. Virtual personalities like the monk [Yang Mun](#) have gained millions of followers on Instagram. Content creator [Shalev Hani](#) claims to be behind this AI-generated character, who shares wisdom on health and mindfulness from what appears to be a Buddhist temple. With Yang Mun, he says he [gained](#) over USD 300,000 in profit in 90 days. The appeal is clear: low costs, 24/7 availability, complete creative control. The problem is equally clear: enthusiasm for AI-generated creator content has [plummeted](#) from 60% in 2023 to just 26% in 2025, revealing **growing skepticism and distrust towards synthetic content**.

However, the AI content problem runs deeper than consumer taste. The Reuters Institute's 2026 [Journalism and Technology Trends](#) report documents something structurally alarming: the proliferation of **AI content farms designed to deceive**. Automated fake news sites, synthetic news anchors presenting fabricated stories, and AI-generated videos deployed as political weapons during elections the world are now integral parts of the information ecosystem. In the Dutch elections, a far-right leader [opened](#) his campaign with an AI-generated video depicting a dystopian future in the Netherlands. A fake video of Ireland's eventual presidential election winner [circulated](#) days before the poll, falsely announcing her withdrawal. These videos are for the large part debunked quickly, but not always, and the platforms that might catch them are currently [dismantling](#) their human moderation teams in favour of AI.

Figure 4: The Rise (and Fall) of AI-Generated Influencers

Note: This article reflects the decline in consumer trust in AI-generated content. From "The 5 communications trends turning 2026 into a reckoning," by S. Pomme, 2026, <https://sophiepomme.com/communications-trends-2026/>. Copyright 2026 by Sophie Pomme.

- **Source 3 (News Article): TechRadar - "Appstinence founder on the fight to help people step back from tech"**

Link:

<https://www.techradar.com/computing/social-media/we-want-to-encourage-other-people-in-our-generation-to-be-the-types-of-people-who-do-not-even-want-to-have-an-ai-friend-appstinence-founder-on-the-fight-to-help-people-step-back-from-tech-and-reconnect-with-real-life>

Date of publication: 29 January 2026

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

Appstinence's work is gliding, to an extent, in the tailwind of another anti-tech provocateur, *The Anxious Generation* Author and Social Psychologist [Jonathan Haidt](#), who has proposed four norms to protect kids from social media:

- No Smartphones Before High School
- No Social Media Before 16
- Phone-Free Schools
- More Independence, Free Play, and Responsibility

Figure 5

Appstinence founder on the fight to help people step back from tech

Note. Article about the movement to reduce the use of social networks and the need for real connection. From We 'want to encourage other people in our generation to be the types of people who don't even want to have an AI friend': Appstinence founder on the fight to help people step back from tech and reconnect with real life, by L. Ulanoff, 2026, <https://www.techradar.com/computing/social-media/we-want-to-encourage-other-people-in-our-generation-to-be-the-types-of-people-who-do-not-even-want-to-have-an-ai-friend-appstinence-founder-on-the-fight-to-help-people-step-back-from-tech-and-reconnect-with-real-life>. Copyright 2026 by TechRadar.

3. Trend description:

Following the massive explosion of generative AI content, 2026 is witnessing AI fatigue among consumers. Audiences are overwhelmed by highly polished but generic, automated posts across social media platforms. Consequently, this trend marks a definitive pivot back to authentic, human-centric storytelling and genuine community building. It is highly relevant because organizations that continue to rely solely on mass-produced, AI-generated corporate messaging are rapidly losing audience trust and engagement. Concepts like “Appstinence” stepping away from algorithmic feeds in favor of real connection gaining momentum. This movement is primarily driven by consumer pushback, digital analyst, and PR experts who are urging brands to prioritize original thought leadership, unscripted video formats, and transparent dialogue over the sheer volume of content production.

4. Your initial reflection:

This trend reminds me that while AI is an excellent productivity tool, it cannot replace the tenets of the industry: empathy, originality, and trust-building. In my internship and future career, I need to focus on developing my unique human voice and critical thinking skills, ensuring I use AI to assist my workflow rather than completely outsourcing my creativity to it.



3. Trend 3:

1. **Trend title:** Transition from PR vanity Metrics to strict ROI measurement. 

2. **Source Details:**

- Source 1 (Industry Report): Onclusive - "PR Trends 2026: Expert Insights on ROI"

Link: <https://onclusive.com/resources/blog/pr-trends-2026/>

Date of publication: January 2026

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

Trend #1: ROI Measurement Will Define PR Success in 2026

Among the PR trends for 2026, one challenge stands out above all others. Most practitioners still cannot connect PR efforts to revenue, and nearly half struggle to prove ROI beyond vanity metrics. As a result, the ability to communicate impact has become the defining test of credibility for communications teams.

To address this, the solution lies in building correlation models that link media coverage directly to the sales pipeline and conversion rates. In addition, communications professionals must translate their work into executive language that resonates with leadership. Otherwise, they risk being viewed as expendable cost centers rather than growth drivers.

In short: Proving ROI is the most critical of all PR and communications trends for 2026 – teams that show business impact will be the ones that thrive.

Figure 6

ROI Measurement Will Define PR Success in 2026

Note: This report emphasizes the shift from virtual metrics to real-world ROI measurement. From PR trends 2026: Expert insights on ROI, by Onclusive, 2026, <https://onclusive.com/resources/blog/pr-trends-2026/>. Copyright 2026 by Onclusive.

- Source 2 (Industry Report): Cision - “Inside PR 2026: PR Trends, AI adoption”

Link:

<https://content-technology.com/media-business/cisions-inside-pr-2026-pr-trends-ai-adoption-comms/>

Date of publication: January 2026

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

What Matters Most in 2026: Awareness, ROI, and Revenue

Brand awareness remains PR's guiding priority, cited by 36 percent of respondents. But the data shows a clear shift toward measurable commercial outcomes at the senior level. Executives (32 percent) and agencies (33 percent) are far more focused on revenue and ROI, while in-house teams and non-executives still lean heavily toward brand awareness, with around 40 percent naming it as their top priority.

This signals a widening alignment gap, with senior leaders pushing for measurable results and frontline teams remaining anchored in brand-building.

Figure 7: *What Matters Most in 2026: Awareness, ROI, and Revenue*

Note. The chart/data shows that leaders are increasingly prioritizing revenue performance over brand recognition.. From Cision's 'Inside PR 2026': *PR trends, AI adoption, comms*, by B. Watts, 2026, <https://content-technology.com/media-business/cisions-inside-pr-2026-pr-trends-ai-adoption-comms/>. Copyright 2026 by Content + Technology.

- Source 3 (Professional Article): Forbes Business Council - "Moving Beyond Vanity Metrics: Marketing KPIs That Matter to the C-Suite"

Link:

<https://www.forbes.com/councils/forbesbusinesscouncil/2025/06/06/moving-beyond-vanity-metrics-marketing-kpis-that-matter-to-the-c-suite/>

Date of publication: June 2025

Date accessed: 31 March 2026

3. Trend Description:

The 2026 communications field has decisively and definitively moved away from superficial “vanity metrics” such as raw impressions, simple follower counts, or outdated Advertising Value Equivalency (AVE). Instead there is now a strict mandate to prove the tangible Return on Investment (ROI) of all public relations activities. This trend involves utilizing advanced analytics to draw a direct line between communication campaigns and core business outcomes, such as lead generation or revenue growth. It is extremely relevant as corporate executives (the C-suite) tighten budgets and demand data-backed accountability. Major PR technology companies like Cision, alongside thought leaders from the Forbes Business Council, are driving this shift by urging professionals to adopt KPIs that truly reflect business impact rather than just brand awareness.

4. Your Initial Reflection:

Entering the communication field, I absorb the mindset of being a skilled storyteller is only half the job; I must also be entirely comfortable with business metrics. Understanding how to align my PR strategies with C-suite expectations and translate creative campaigns into solid, measurable business value will be essential for my career growth.

Thousands of social followers. Millions of ad impressions. Coast-to-coast media coverage. It’s thrilling to see the charts and graphs depicting an abundance of eyeballs on the business—but are these figures reflecting progress toward defined objectives? Or are they dressing up a missed target?

Vanity metrics are aptly named for inflating an ego or providing a false sense of progress. They look attractive on the surface, but a deeper and more strategic dive may reveal that those eyeballs are not actually representing the target audience, nor are they accurately reflecting genuine interest or action related to brand awareness and lead generation, among other business goals.

Figure 8: Moving Beyond Vanity Metrics

Note: This article guides marketers and PR professionals to focus on core KPIs that deliver business value. From Moving beyond vanity metrics: Marketing KPIs that matter to the C-suite, by A. Aker, 2025, <https://www.forbes.com/councils/forbesbusinesscouncil/2025/06/06/moving-beyond-vanity-metrics-marketing-kpis-that-matter-to-the-c-suite/>. Copyright 2025 by Forbes.

Trend Analysis:

1. Trend overview

The growing phenomenon of AI Content Fatigue represents a critical pivot in the media landscape. Following the high volume of Generative AI, audiences are increasingly overwhelmed by a saturated market of synthetic, automated and repetitive content. This is a remarkable trend, which signals a transition from a sheer content volume back to quality, verified facts, and authentic storytelling (ADM+S Centre, 2025).

The major players in this trend occupy opposing sides of the spectrum. On one side, tech conglomerates and large media agencies aggressively drive AI automation to maximize efficiency. On the opposing side, ethical research centers (such as the ADM+S Centre), rigorous journalistic institutions and digital-native consumers act as powerful counter-forces, actively pushing back against algorithmic feeds in favor of human - verified formats.

Several interconnected drivers fuel this structural shift. Technologically, the drastically lowered barrier to content creation has caused an unprecedented oversupply of generic media. On the political and social front, the alarming proliferation of deepfakes and AI-generated misinformation has significantly undermined audience confidence in digital media ecosystems. Regarding the demographic level, particularly among gen Z, growing screen fatigue is reshaping consumption behaviours, users are actively shifting toward niche, community - oriented platforms that value authentic human interaction over algorithmically curated, Ai-produced content. This behavioural migration is compelling organisations to critically reassess their dependence on generative tools..

2. Impact on the Industry

The backlash against AI-generated content is fundamentally reshaping standard practices and posing severe challenges within the communications industry. The most pressing challenge lies in the rapid erosion of institutional trust. As synthetic content floods the ecosystem, communicators must expend significantly more resources simply to prove the authenticity of their messaging. However, this crisis of credibility creates a unique opportunity: organizations that transparently invest in human-led journalism and deeply empathetic brand storytelling can definitively differentiate themselves in a sea of algorithmic noise.

When thoroughly analyzing this trend, evidence from three primary sources- Thomson et al (2025), Deloitte (2023), and Narayanan (2025) evaluates the

impact through distinctly different analytical lenses.

Approaching the trend from a strict ethical and journalistic standpoint, Thomson et al (2025) highlight severe institutional concerns over misleading synthetic content. Their report underscores that the widespread use of photorealistic AI makes it nearly impossible to distinguish between authentic and synthetic content. The immediate impact on the industry is an existential crisis of credibility, threatening historical archiving and daily news consumption. Therefore, the practice of content creation must now be heavily augmented with rigorous human fact-checking to protect public reality (Thompson et al 2025).

In contrast to the journalistic focus, Deloitte (2023) examines the trend through a commercial and digital marketing lens. While acknowledging that generative tools theoretically support greater creativity, Deloitte (2023) warns that they primarily enable a glut of cheap, derivative content. The industry impact here is heavily economic, as this over-saturation severely challenges “human-to-human authenticity” on social platforms. For corporate communicators, simply flooding digital channels with automated posts is now a counterproductive strategy that drives audience churn. While Thomson et al (2025) focus on the loss of truth, Deloitte (2023) highlights the loss of consumer engagement and ROI.

Offering a technological governance perspective, Princeton Professor Arvind Naarayanan (2025) challenges the systemic AI hype that underlies much of this fatigue. Naarayanan (2025) identifies a fundamental disconnect within the industry: although AI models demonstrate exceptional performance in bounded domains such as mathematics, such capability does not necessarily translate to practical utility in real-world applications. His critique is distinctive in that it targets the foundational narrative of AI efficiency itself, rather than its surface-level misapplications. He further cautions that amplifying unverified claims risks substantial reputational consequences for communications professionals.

Comparing these sources reveals a multi-faceted industry impact: human intervention is urgently required to preserve journalistic integrity (Thomson et al, 2025), sustain commercial engagement (Deloitte, 2023), and counter systemic technological hype (Naarayanan, 2025).

3. Connection to Your Internship / Career Aspirations

During my Media and Communication Internship, I have directly observed the practical implications of AI content fatigue. While the initial industry push was to utilize Large Language Models (LLMs) for drafting quick press releases or social media copy to maximize output, it quickly became apparent that audiences do not engage with robotic, hyper-polished corporate speak. I noticed that campaigns relying heavily on AI generation often lacked the nuanced tone of

voice required to build genuine community trust, aligning perfectly with Deloitte's (2023) warnings about derivative content. This was further reinforced through running Carne Gemstone, my own crystal lifestyle brand, where bilingual storytelling in Vietnamese and English consistently outperformed templated AI-drafted captions in both reach and audience response.

The implications of this trend for my future career are profound. As I transition into a full-time communications role, the baseline expectation will inevitably include AI literacy knowing how to prompt and generate basic content. However, this technical proficiency will no longer serve as a unique professional differentiator. Instead, the true value of a PR or media practitioner will be anchored in their irreplaceable human skills. My future employers will not hire me for my ability to act as a human API for ChatGPT; they will hire me to navigate complex ethical dilemmas, build empathetic relationships with stakeholders, and protect the organization's reputation against the risk of synthetic misinformation.

In response to this structural shift, I am actively identifying specific knowledge areas I must develop. First, I need to master advanced digital fact-checking and media literacy to safeguard brand integrity against deepfakes and AI hallucinations, a risk heavily emphasized by Narayanan (2025). Second, I must step outside the industry bubble that Narayanan (2025) warns about, ensuring my communication strategies are grounded in what everyday audiences actually find useful and trustworthy, rather than blindly following technological hype. Finally and most importantly, I must hone the art of authentic, unscripted storytelling which is a skill I am actively developing through editorial writing and community-driven content across both my academic and professional work. Cultivating a distinct, empathetic human voice will be my most powerful asset in an increasingly automated industry, ensuring that my future work cuts through the algorithmic noise to forge genuine connections. ♥

Linkedin Post:

Did you know that despite the hype around Generative AI, audiences are actually craving less synthetic content?

We are officially facing an industry-wide crisis: "AI Content Fatigue". The flood of hyper automated, generic posts is severely eroding public trust and driving a massive demand for authentic storytelling.

My recent RMIT internship research highlights this critical shift. [The ADM+S 2025 Gen AI and Journalism report](#) warns that misleading synthetic media directly threatens institutional

credibility. Furthermore, [Deloitte \(2023\)](#) notes that a glut of cheap, derivative content destroys human-to-human engagement.

This trend is a massive wake-up call for my career aspirations. While AI prompting is an expected baseline skill, my true value as a future PR professional lies in rigorous fact-checking, strategic thinking, and deeply empathetic communication.

Are we becoming better communicators with AI, or just sounding exactly like everyone else? I'd love to hear your thoughts. Let's discuss it below!

 AI disclosure: AI tools were used to brainstorm structural ideas for this post. All source selection, analysis, and personal reflections are entirely my own.

#Communications #GenerativeAI #RMIT #PublicRelations

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